

British monarchs

The history of England, and later Britain, is tied together by a string of kings and queens. Early on, royals could start wars, break from the Church, and punish the country's leaders. Today, the Queen has little power but upholds long and popular traditions.

757-1066

ANGLO-SAXONS

After the Romans left Britain in the 5th century CE, the land was attacked by invaders and split into warring kingdoms. The leader of one, Egbert, became the first king of England. Throughout the Saxon period, powerful kings fended off Viking raids, but England was ruled by Viking monarchs for over 25 years.



OFFA
757-96
The king of Mercia (central England) expanded his kingdom north and south and protected it by building a huge dyke along the Welsh border.



EGBERT
802-39
Originally King of Wessex, Egbert gradually increased the power and influence of his kingdom. His authority was recognized throughout most of England after he defeated Mercia and Northumbria.

757-96	OFFA	955-59	EADWIG
802-39	EGBERT	959-75	EDGAR
839-56	AETHELWULF	975-78	EDWARD II "THE MARTYR"
856-60	AETHELBALD	979-1013 AND 1014-16	AETHELRED II "THE UNREADY"
860-66	AETHELBERT	1013-14	SVEIN
866-71	AETHELRED I	1016	EDMUND II "IRONSIDE"
871-99	ALFRED "THE GREAT"	1016-35	CANUTE
899-924	EDWARD "THE ELDER"	1035-40	HAROLD I "HAREFOOT"
925-40	ATHELSTAN	1040-42	HARDICANUTE
940-46	EDMUND I	1042-66	EDWARD III "THE CONFESSOR"
946-55	EADRED	1066	HAROLD II

1485-1603

TUDORS

The Tudors ruled with an iron fist and were not always popular, but they fostered national pride and parliament grew in strength under them. The manufacturing and merchant classes rose in status, and architecture, literature, and theatre blossomed. Playwright William Shakespeare was a leading light.



HENRY VIII
1509-47
Famous for his six wives (he divorced two and beheaded two), Henry VIII made himself head of the Church of England and bankrupted his country.

1485-1509	HENRY VII TUDOR
1509-47	HENRY VIII
1547-53	EDWARD VI
1553	LADY JANE GREY
1553-58	MARY I
1558-1603	ELIZABETH I



ELIZABETH I
1558-1603
Strong-willed Elizabeth was a clever politician with loyal followers. Under her reign trade, exploration, and prosperity increased.



MARY I
1553-58
Nicknamed Bloody Mary, Henry VIII's eldest daughter burned protestants after she seized the throne, and restored the Roman Catholic Church.

1461-85

YORKISTS

This branch of the House of Plantagenets had a strong claim to the throne. After Richard of York was killed in the Battle of Wakefield (1460), his son Edward became the first Yorkist king. William Caxton invented the first printing press in this period.

1461-70	EDWARD IV
1471-83	EDWARD IV
1483	EDWARD V
1483-85	RICHARD III

1399-1413	HENRY IV
1413-22	HENRY V
1422-61	HENRY VI
1470-71	HENRY VI



HENRY VI
1422-61 AND 1470-71
After losing his father's gains in France, a failing mind cost Henry VI the throne for a time.

RICHARD III
1483-85
The last English king to die on a battlefield, Richard III may have had a role in the death of his two nephews, the princes, in the Tower of London.



1603-1749

STUARTS

This dynasty was dominated by political battles between King and Parliament, which ended with a civil war and a beheading. Although the Stuarts believed they had a god-given right to rule, they were tolerant of Catholics, and made peace with Spain. They were patrons of the arts and left a legacy of beautiful art and architecture.



JAMES I
1603-25
Scotland and England were united when this Scottish king took the throne. He ruled for long periods without Parliament, and was the target of Guy Fawkes's failed Gunpowder Plot.



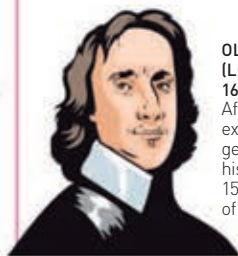
CHARLES I
1625-49
This stubborn king believed in his divine right to rule and stamped on any opposition. Defeated by Oliver Cromwell in the Civil War, he was tried and executed by his parliament.

1649-59

COMMONWEALTH

For the first and only time in its history, England was a Commonwealth (or republic) without a king or queen. Ruled by puritan Oliver Cromwell and his Parliament, the country took Jamaica from the Spanish and defeated the Dutch at sea.

1649-53	REPUBLIC
1653-58	OLIVER CROMWELL (LORD PROTECTOR)
1658-59	RICHARD CROMWELL (LORD PROTECTOR)



OLIVER CROMWELL (LORD PROTECTOR)
1653-58
After Charles I was executed, this leading general established his own council of 15 and a parliament of 400. He was followed by his son Richard.

1660-1714

STUARTS

After Charles II was restored to the throne London suffered two disasters – a plague killed more than 100,000 people and a great fire destroyed most of the city. James II tried to restore the Catholic faith but fled when William of Orange was invited to restore rights in the Glorious Revolution.

1660-85	CHARLES II
1685-88	JAMES II
1689-94	WILLIAM III OF ORANGE AND MARY II (JOINTLY)
1694-1702	WILLIAM III
1702-14	ANNE

CHARLES II
1660-85
This "merry monarch" had many interests and many mistresses. He took a keen interest in architecture and science, and introduced the new sport of yachting to England.



1714-1901

HANOVERIANS

The Hanoverian dynasty saw many changes. Robert Walpole became the first Prime Minister to German-speaking George I, and Britain developed into an industrial society. By the end of Queen Victoria's reign, Britain's economic power was being challenged by other nations such as Germany and the United States.

1714-27	GEORGE I
1727-60	GEORGE II
1760-1820	GEORGE III
1820-30	GEORGE IV
1830-37	WILLIAM IV
1837-1901	VICTORIA

GEORGE I
1714-27
This German-born king faced rebellion in Scotland then scandal when a South Sea trading company went bust and ruined thousands of investors.

